



BUYING GUIDE / UAE

How to Buy Property in the UAE as an International Buyer

A practical guide to finding and buying a UAE golf home, wherever you live.

For international buyers • Golf Homes International

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International buyers can own property outright in the UAE, and the process is quick and well regulated. Much of it can be handled from abroad, but completion takes place in person, either by you or by a representative. Buyers from Europe, the Americas, Asia and across the Middle East purchase homes in Dubai and Abu Dhabi every year, many of them without living in the country. There is no annual property tax and no capital gains tax on a sale for individual owners, which is a large part of the appeal.

Each emirate sets its own property rules, so this guide focuses on Dubai and Abu Dhabi, where most international golf buyers look. It covers the full process from start to finish: choosing a freehold area, the legal steps for resale and off-plan homes, the costs to budget for, mortgage options, running costs as an owner and how property links to UAE residency.

The buying process, step by step

Step 1: Research and choose your location

Dubai has the widest choice of established golf communities in the UAE. Jumeirah Golf Estates is built around its two championship courses, Emirates Hills is set around The Montgomerie, and Dubai Hills Estate combines an 18-hole course with schools, parks and a large mall. In Abu Dhabi, Saadiyat Island pairs beach living with the Saadiyat Beach Golf Club, while Yas Island sits beside Yas Links and close to the airport. [Browse our UAE golf homes](#) to see what is available now.

Take your time with this stage. Visit the communities, drive the routes to schools, offices and the airport, and look at what is finished today rather than what a masterplan promises. The right location depends on whether the home is for holidays, relocation, rental income or a mix of all three.

Our advice

Spend a few days on the ground before deciding. Communities that look similar on a map can feel very different in person. Speak to us and we can help you plan viewings across Dubai and Abu Dhabi.

[Contact us](#) to arrange viewings or a call about the communities that suit you.

Step 2: Confirm the property is in a freehold area

Foreign nationals can buy freehold property only in areas designated for international ownership. In Dubai, these freehold areas include most of the popular golf and waterfront communities. In Abu Dhabi, foreign buyers can own freehold in designated investment zones, including Saadiyat Island, Yas Island and Al Reem Island.

Your lawyer will confirm the status of the specific plot and the type of title you will receive before you commit. This matters most for villas and plots on the edge of a community, where designations can differ.

What you need

A valid passport is enough to buy. You do not need a UAE residence visa or Emirates ID, and there is no local tax number to apply for before purchase.

Buying through a company

Some buyers hold property through a company, for privacy, succession or joint-investment reasons. Companies can own property in Dubai's freehold areas, but the company must first be [registered with the Dubai Land Department](#), and a free-zone company needs a no-objection certificate from its licensing authority. A company structure adds set-up and annual costs. Unlike an individual owner, a company may also be subject to UAE corporate tax on rental income and gains, and the structure can affect residency eligibility, so take legal and tax advice before choosing it.

Step 3: Arrange your funds

A UAE bank account is not a legal requirement to buy, but completion payments are usually made by manager's cheques issued by a UAE bank, so many buyers open a UAE account or arrange the payment with their bank. If you are buying with a UAE mortgage, the lender will usually open an account for you as part of the loan.

Expect to show where your funds come from. UAE banks, developers and trustee offices must follow anti-money laundering rules, and large transfers from overseas will need supporting evidence. Allow time for international payments to clear and consider a currency specialist rather than a high-street bank for the transfer.

Step 4: Appoint an independent lawyer

Using a lawyer is not compulsory in the UAE, and many buyers complete through agents alone. We strongly recommend one. An independent lawyer protects your interests, and yours alone, at the points where mistakes are expensive: the sale agreement, the off-plan contract, the deposit and any dispute with a developer or seller.

A good UAE property lawyer will check the title and any mortgage on it, confirm the seller's right to sell, review the Form F or developer contract, advise on joint ownership and explain how UAE succession rules affect you. Many buyers also use their lawyer to prepare a UAE will at the same time.

Our UAE legal partner

We work with an established UAE-based law firm that supports international buyers with sale agreement and off-plan contract reviews, purchase guidance and UAE wills. You remain free to appoint any lawyer you choose.

[Ask us for an introduction](#) and we will connect you directly with our legal partner, who can review your documents before you sign.

Step 5: Make an offer and sign the sale agreement (Form F)

When you have found a resale property, you make an offer through a broker licensed by the Real Estate Regulatory Agency (RERA). Once the price is agreed, buyer, seller and brokers sign the Dubai Land Department's standard sale contract, known as Form F or the MOU. It sets out the price, the deposit, the completion date and the penalties if either side withdraws.

The buyer typically pays a deposit of 10% of the purchase price when Form F is signed, usually as a security cheque held by the broker until completion. Your lawyer should review Form F before you sign, particularly any conditions for mortgage approval.

Timing

Cash resale purchases in Dubai often complete within 30 days of signing Form F. Allow 6 to 8 weeks if you are using a mortgage.

Step 6: Inspect the property and complete your checks

Before transfer, your lawyer or broker will confirm that the seller owns the property, whether it is mortgaged and whether any service charges are outstanding. The developer must issue a no-objection certificate (NOC) confirming there are no unpaid charges before a Dubai sale can proceed.

A professional snagging or building inspection is worthwhile for villas, older homes and properties with pools and landscaping. It is not standard practice in the UAE, but the cost is modest and it can give you grounds to renegotiate or ask for repairs before completion.

Golf-specific checks

A home on a golf course needs a few extra checks:

- Views: find out whether the course view is protected, or whether land between you and the fairway could be developed later.

- The course itself: ask who owns and runs it, and whether there are plans to redesign or reduce it.
- Service charges: check whether your community charges contribute to landscaping or course-side areas, and how they have changed over recent years.
- Membership: owning a home on the course does not give you playing rights. Ask the club about membership options, waiting lists and any resident rates before you buy.

Step 7: Buying off-plan

Many UAE golf homes are bought off-plan, directly from the developer, with payments spread across construction. You sign the developer's sale and purchase agreement (SPA), and the sale is entered in the interim register, known as Oqood in Dubai. The same 4% registration fee applies in Dubai, with the buyer usually paying it at the start.

In Dubai, off-plan payments must go into a project escrow account regulated by the Dubai Land Department. Check that the developer is approved and the project is registered using the [Dubai Land Department's developer search](#) and [project status enquiry](#). Abu Dhabi has equivalent protection: off-plan payments go into a project escrow account under the emirate's real estate law, overseen by the [Abu Dhabi Real Estate Centre](#).

If you might want to sell before handover, check the SPA first. In Dubai, the developer must issue a no-objection certificate and the sale must be registered with the Land Department. Developers typically require 30% to 40% of the price to be paid before they allow a resale, and some set a higher threshold.

New builds

Only pay into the project's registered escrow account, never to an individual or a sales office account. Have your lawyer review the SPA for handover dates, delay provisions and what happens if you want to sell before completion.

Step 8: Complete at the trustee office

Completion in Dubai takes place at a Real Estate Registration Trustee office, which acts on behalf of the Dubai Land Department. Buyer and seller, or their representatives under power of attorney, attend together. The trustee checks the documents, the transfer fee is paid, the balance goes to the seller by manager's cheque and the new title deed is issued electronically the same day. In Abu Dhabi, the transfer is registered through the DARI platform.

Buying without travelling to the UAE

You don't have to fly out for completion, but someone does need to be there. The transfer is completed in person at a Dubai trustee office, so if you can't attend, you'll need a representative on the ground acting under a power of attorney.

A UAE property power of attorney is much more specific than a UK one. It must expressly authorise the exact transaction, using the wording the Dubai Land Department requires, and if you're buying jointly it must state your ownership share. A general power of attorney, or a UK lasting power of attorney, won't be accepted.

If you sign it outside the UAE, it must be notarised and then attested in stages: in the UK by the FCDO, then by the UAE Embassy and the UAE Ministry of Foreign Affairs. You'll need to present the original paper document, with an Arabic legal translation by a UAE-licensed translator. A power of attorney signed abroad is only accepted for two years, so time it with your purchase and allow several weeks for the paperwork.

Choose your representative carefully. Signing a sale agreement or transfer for someone else carries real responsibility, and real risk for you if anything goes wrong. Most buyers appoint someone they trust personally, such as a family member or business partner. Lawyers in the UAE don't routinely act as attorney for property purchases, so ask your lawyer to draft or check the document instead, keeping the powers as narrow as possible.

Abu Dhabi follows its own process through the [DARI platform](#), so confirm the requirements there before you sign.

On the day

Have your manager's cheques and transfer fees ready in advance. If funds are coming from abroad, move them early, since exchange rates can make a real difference to the final cost.

Costs of buying in the UAE

In addition to the purchase price, budget for the following costs. The figures below are for Dubai, where the fees are set by the Dubai Land Department. They apply equally to all buyers regardless of nationality. The official schedules are on the Land Department's [property sale registration](#) and [mortgage registration](#) pages.

Cost	Amount	What to know
Dubai Land Department transfer fee	4%	Officially split 2% buyer and 2% seller, but buyers usually pay the full 4%. Check the sale agreement.
Trustee office fee	AED 4,000 + VAT	For properties of AED 500,000 or more. AED 2,000 + VAT below that.
Title deed and registration fees	About AED 520	Title deed, property map and small administration fees.
Agency commission	~2% + VAT	Market standard for resale purchases. Usually none on off-plan homes bought directly from a developer.
Mortgage registration	0.25% of the loan	If financing, plus a further AED 4,000 + VAT trustee fee.
Mortgage arrangement and valuation	Up to 1% + valuation fee	Varies by lender. Some banks waive the arrangement fee.

Total to budget

For a Dubai resale property, allow around 6% to 7% of the purchase price in buying costs, or around 7% to 7.5% with a mortgage. For an off-plan home bought directly from the developer, allow around 4% to 5%. Example: on an AED 3,000,000 resale villa in Dubai, paying the full transfer fee and agency commission, budget roughly AED 188,000 in buying costs on top of the property price.

Abu Dhabi works differently. The transfer fee is 2% of the price or the official valuation, whichever is higher, set through the [DARI platform](#), and the buyer's share is agreed as part of the sale. With agency commission and administration fees, Abu Dhabi buyers typically budget around 3% to 5% on top of the price, depending on how the transfer fee is shared.

Mortgage options for international buyers

UAE banks lend to both residents and non-residents, although non-residents have fewer lenders to choose from and usually need a larger deposit. The [Central Bank of the UAE](#) sets the maximum loan sizes, and individual banks often lend less.

- For a first home, expatriates can borrow up to 80% of the value on properties up to AED 5 million, and up to 70% above that.
- For a second home or investment property, the maximum is 60%.
- For off-plan purchases, the maximum is 50% regardless of buyer or value.
- Terms run up to 25 years, and repayments across all your debts cannot exceed 50% of your monthly income.
- Expatriates can borrow no more than seven times their annual income.

- Non-resident buyers are usually offered less than residents, and some banks cap non-resident loans at around 50%.

UAE mortgages are in dirhams, which have been pegged to the US dollar since 1997. If you earn in sterling, euros or another currency, consider the exchange rate risk on monthly repayments. A pre-approval before you view seriously will confirm your budget and make your offer more credible.

A specialist UAE mortgage broker can compare lenders that accept buyers from your country and income type.

Tax obligations as a property owner

The UAE is one of the most tax-efficient places in the world to own property. There is no annual property tax, no personal income tax on rent and no capital gains tax when an individual sells. Your home country may still tax rental income or gains, so speak to a tax adviser in your country of residence before you buy.

VAT on property

The first sale of a new home within three years of completion is zero-rated for VAT, and all later sales are exempt, so buyers of homes do not pay VAT on the price itself. VAT at 5% applies to agency commission, trustee fees, legal fees and service charges. The [Federal Tax Authority](#) confirms the treatment.

Service charges

Owners pay annual service charges for the upkeep of shared areas, landscaping, security and community facilities. These vary widely between communities, so check the figure for the specific building or community in the Dubai Land Department's [Service Charge Index](#) before you buy. Golf club membership is separate and not included in owning a home on the course.

Housing fee and utilities

In Dubai, a municipality housing fee is collected monthly through the DEWA utility bill, alongside electricity, water and cooling. Tenants pay 5% of their annual rent; if you live in your own home, check how the fee applies to your DEWA account. Abu Dhabi charges a similar municipality fee to residents through ADDC.

Renting out your home

If you plan to let the property, the rules depend on the type of let. In Dubai, short-term holiday lets need a [holiday home permit from the Department of Economy and Tourism](#) before the property is listed, and the permit is renewed each year. Long-term tenancies must be registered through the Land Department's [Ejari system](#). Check your building or community rules too, as some restrict holiday lets. Abu Dhabi has its own licensing for holiday homes.

For an individual owner, rental income from property is not treated as business income for UAE corporate tax, according to the [Federal Tax Authority](#). Your home country may still tax it.

Wills and succession

This is the point international buyers most often overlook. Without a registered UAE will, an owner's UAE property can be frozen while the estate is settled, and succession may not follow your wishes. Non-Muslim owners can register a will through the [DIFC Courts Wills Service](#) or the [Abu Dhabi Civil Family Court](#). Our UAE legal partner prepares UAE wills for international owners and can advise on the right route when you buy.

If you buy jointly, there is no automatic right of survivorship in the UAE. Each owner holds a separate share, and without a registered UAE will, a deceased owner's share can be frozen until the estate is settled. Couples buying together should make their wills at the same time as they buy.

A note on residency

Buying property does not automatically give you the right to live in the UAE, but it can qualify you for a residence visa. Under the [UAE Golden Residency](#), owners of one or more properties worth at least AED 2 million in total, registered in their own name, can apply for long-term residency. Property held through a company may not qualify. The property can be financed through an approved UAE bank, and off-plan homes bought from an approved developer can also qualify.

The application is made through the Federal Authority for Identity, Citizenship, Customs and Port Security (ICP) or, in Dubai, the GDRFA. An immigration specialist can confirm the current process and documents for your circumstances.

Ready to look at homes? [Browse our current UAE golf properties](#), or [contact us](#) to discuss what you are looking for.

Ready to start your search?

Speak to us about buying golf property in Dubai or Abu Dhabi. We can also introduce you to our UAE legal partner. No pressure, no obligation, just straightforward guidance from people who know the market.

[Contact GHI to request an introduction](#)

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Important information

This guide is provided by Golf Homes International for general information only. It does not constitute legal, tax, financial, mortgage, immigration or other professional advice, and it should not be relied on as such. We are not a law firm and we do not provide legal, tax or financial advice.

Property law, registration fees, lending rules, residency criteria and tax treatment in the UAE differ between emirates and change regularly. The information in this guide is correct as of October 2026. Figures are indicative, relate to Dubai unless stated otherwise, and will vary with each transaction. While we take care to keep the content accurate, we make no representation or warranty, express or implied, as to its accuracy, completeness or currency.

Before making any decision or entering into any commitment, you should obtain independent advice, based on your own circumstances, from suitably qualified professionals in the UAE and, where relevant, in your country of residence.

Any introduction we make to a law firm, mortgage adviser or other third party is offered for convenience only. Those providers are independent of us, you engage them directly and on their own terms, and they are solely responsible for the advice and services they provide. You remain free to appoint any adviser you choose.

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